This book isn’t meant to be a reference manual for Rails. Our experience is that reference manuals aren’t the way most people learn. Instead, we show most of the modules and many of their methods, either by example or narratively in the text, in the context of how these components are used and how they fit together.

Nor do we have hundreds of pages of API listings. There’s a good reason for this: you get that documentation whenever you install Rails, and it’s guaranteed to be more up-to-date than the material in this book. If you install Rails using RubyGems (which we recommend), start the gem documentation server (using the `gem server` command), and you can access all the Rails APIs by pointing your browser at http://localhost:8808.

In addition, you’ll see that Rails helps you by producing responses that clearly identify any error found as well as traces that tell you not only the point at which the error was found but also how you got there. You’ll see an example here. If you need additional information, peek ahead to *Iteration E2: Handling Errors*, to see how to insert logging statements.

If you get really stuck, plenty of online resources can help. In addition to the code listings mentioned, you can find more resources on the Pragmatic Bookshelf site page for this book, including links to the book forum and errata.[7] The resources listed on these pages are shared resources. Feel free to post not only questions and problems to the forum but also any suggestions and answers you may have to questions that others have posted.

Let’s get started! The first steps are to install Ruby and Rails and to verify the installation with a simple demonstration.

Footnotes

[1] http://rubyonrails.org/doctrine/

[2] http://agilemanifesto.org/

[3] https://github.com/turbolinks/turbolinks/blob/master/README.md

[4] http://guides.rubyonrails.org/engines.html